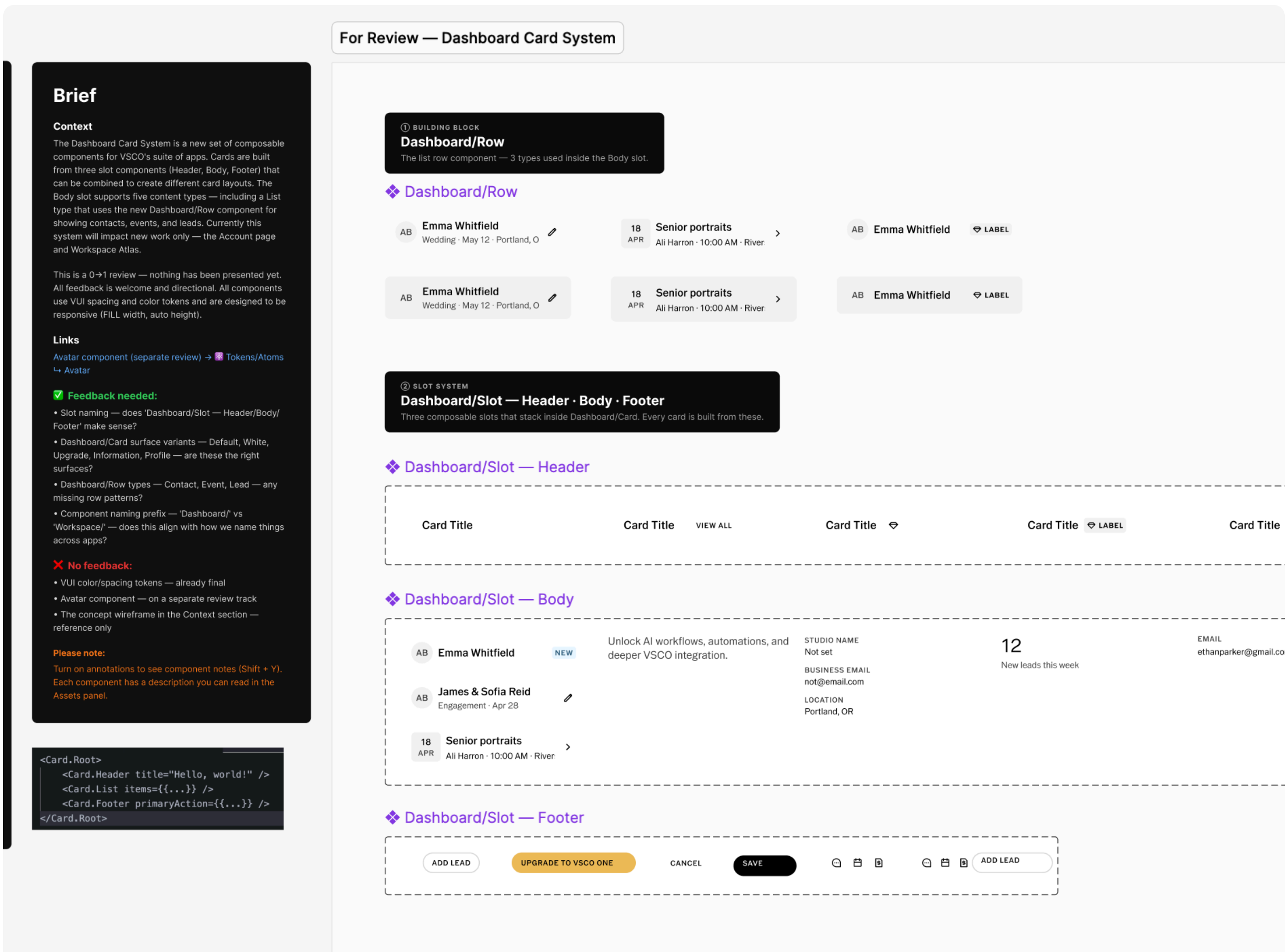
AI-Powered Design Ops

Head of Product Design, VSCO · 2025–2026

The organization · Design leadership · AI tooling



Head of Design. Zero specialist hires. Here's how the org scales without them.

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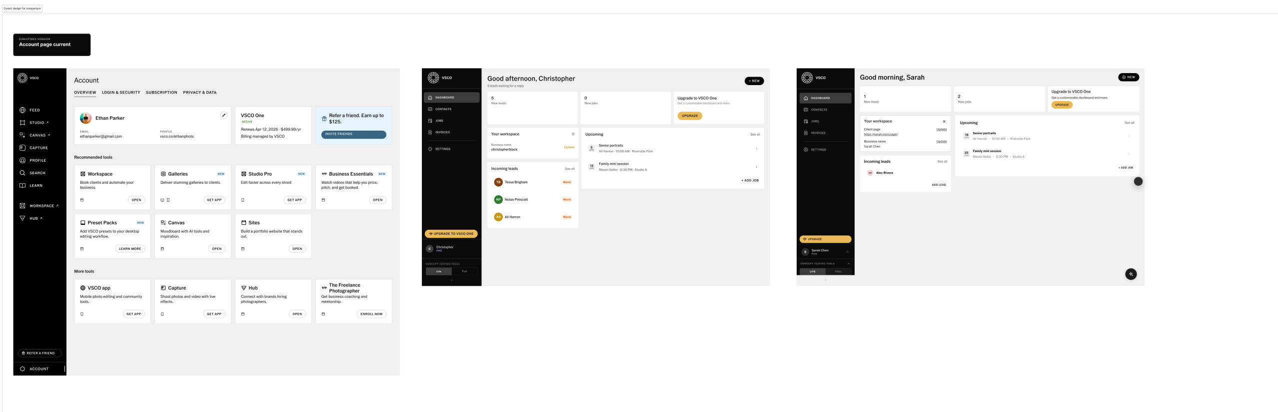
SPECIALIST HIRES TO MAIN... QUALITY

4

...NC WITHOUT A DEDICATED DS ROLE

Four platforms. No specialist.



Same sprint, already drifting. Account page left, Workspace Atlas center and right, built without a shared source of truth.

At VSCO, web, React Native, iOS, and Android each had their own Figma library. They had grown independently and diverged. The standard fix requires a dedicated design systems specialist. That was not an option.

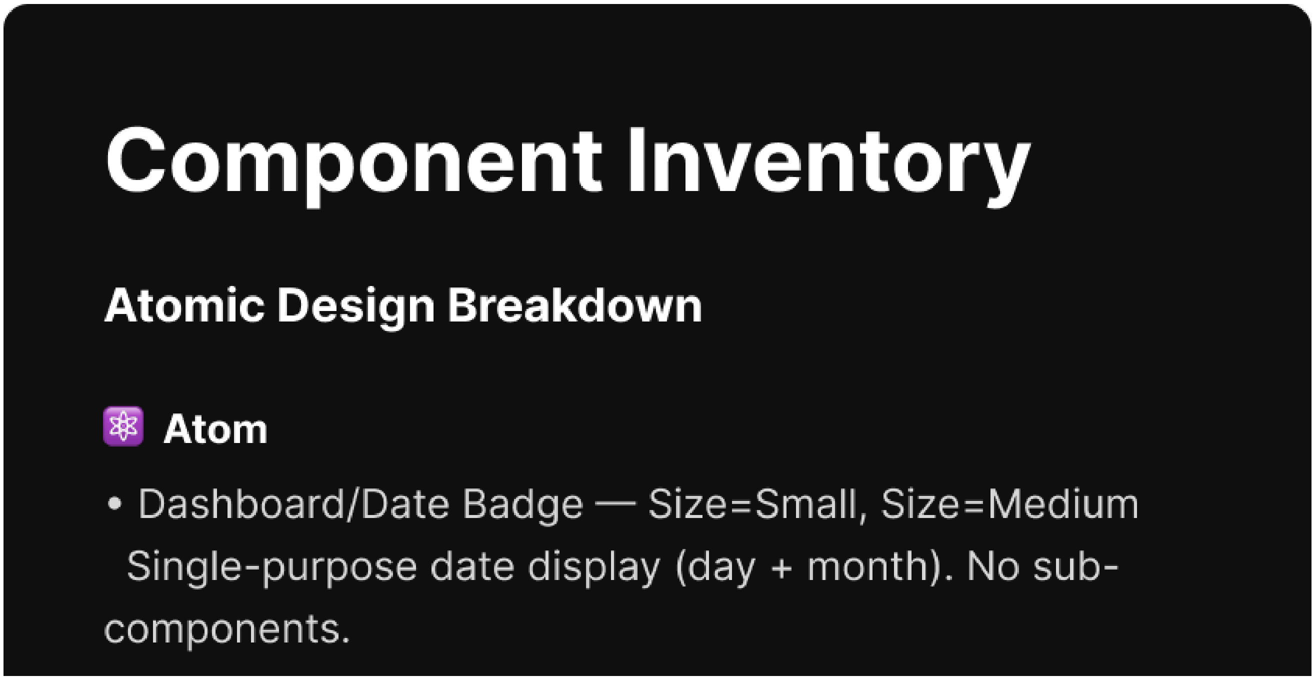
The solution needed to replace specialist capacity without adding headcount.

Instead: a Claude skill with write access to the live Figma file via the Plugin API. Not advisory AI. Operational AI that inspects, fixes, and reports.

What the workflow does

- **Component check:** reads every component against a structural checklist. Variant structure, auto-layout, token bindings, layer naming, descriptions.
- **Tiered report:** passing, issues, blockers, with specific fix instructions per node.
- **Direct fixes:** rebuilds auto-layout, rewires token bindings, creates missing variants, corrects property naming.

- **Verified:** every change confirmed before moving on. Progress blocked until every modified node pass
- **Slack summary:** what was audited, what changed, what needs human review. Engineers notified when their components update.



The audit output: component inventory with atomic breakdown, library candidacy, and code priority.

modal.md

```
STRUCTURE
  sections: header · body · footer (optional)
  radius: radius.standard (4px)
  backdrop: color.overlay.scrim · 40% opacity

HEADER
  font: vsco-gothic · 17/semibold · caps
  color: color.text.primary
  close icon: optional — omit if footer has dismiss button
  padding: 24 24 16

BODY
  font: 16/medium desktop · 13/medium mobile
  content: text | rows | form | image
```

Engineering-side guardrails

The Figma library has composite components designers use to work fast. The code design system has primitives. Getting them to stay in sync required more than governance of Figma files.

The React and React Native design libraries now include written guidance documents that engineering's Cursor agents read when expanding components. Instead of pre-building every variant, the docs describe what configurations are valid. The agent checks its output against the guidelines rather than guessing from a visual. Consistency at scale without pre-building every permutation.

This extended the design system to serve a third consumer: AI agents, alongside designers and engineers.

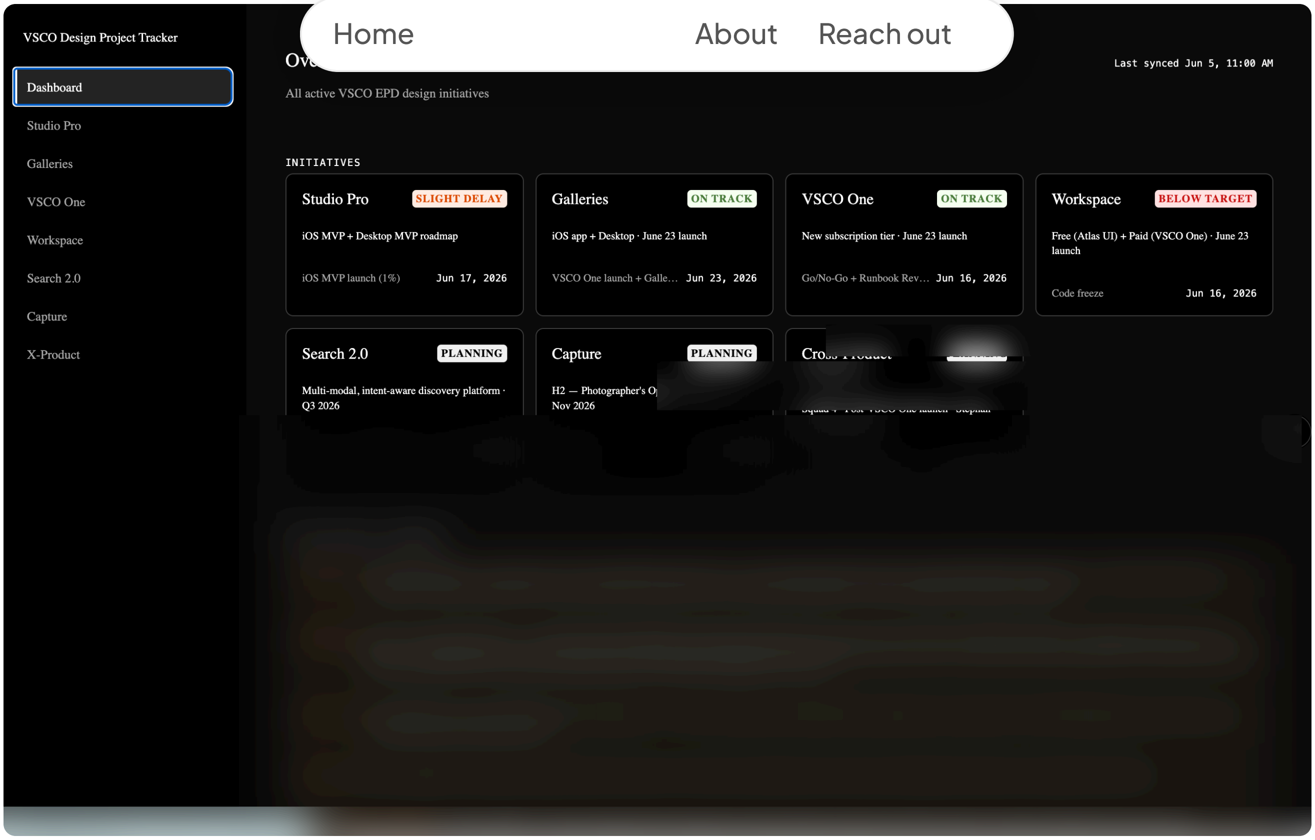
Visibility without the overhead

The hardest part of leading a design team across multiple squads is staying current. Updates live in Confluence pages, Jira boards, PDF briefs, and Google Sheets. No one has time to read all of them.

VSCO Design Project Tracker

A scheduled Claude artifact that runs every day without being triggered. It reads Confluence initiative pages across every squad, pulls current status, and renders a live dashboard: what each team is working on, whether they are on track, and direct links to Figma files, Jira boards, and source documents.

One view instead of fifteen tabs. Leadership visibility without a status meeting.



All active VSCO design initiatives in one view. Status, key dates, links — no status meeting required.

Daily brief

Each morning, a scheduled Claude skill pulls from calendar and Slack context and generates a design team brief: priorities, blockers, upcoming reviews, anything that needs attention that day. Formatted and posted to Slack automatically.

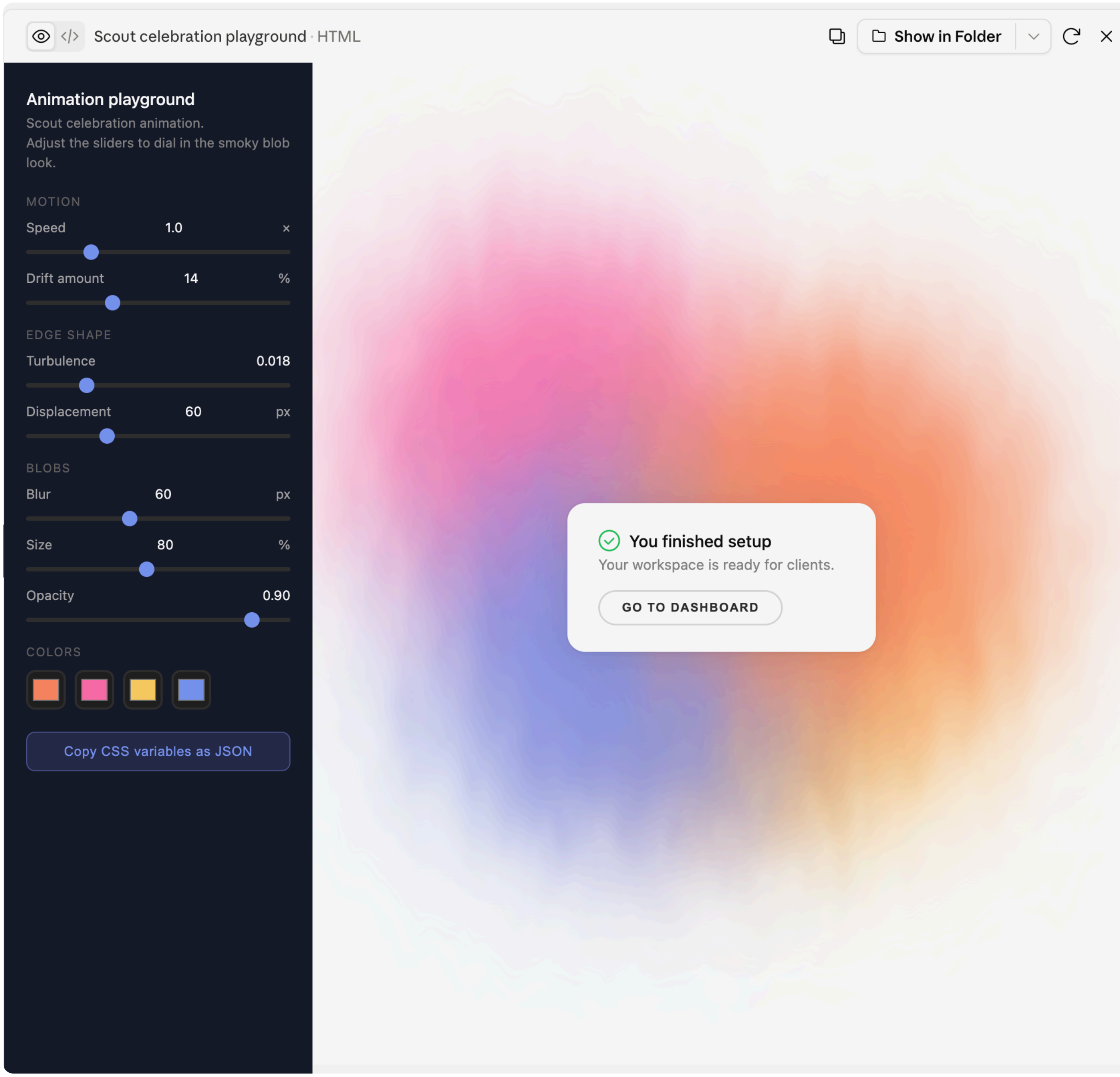
Solving craft problems without specialists

The instinct whenever something complex comes up: solve it before proposing a hire. Animation, conversion design, interaction research — each of these would have stalled or required outside help. None of them did.

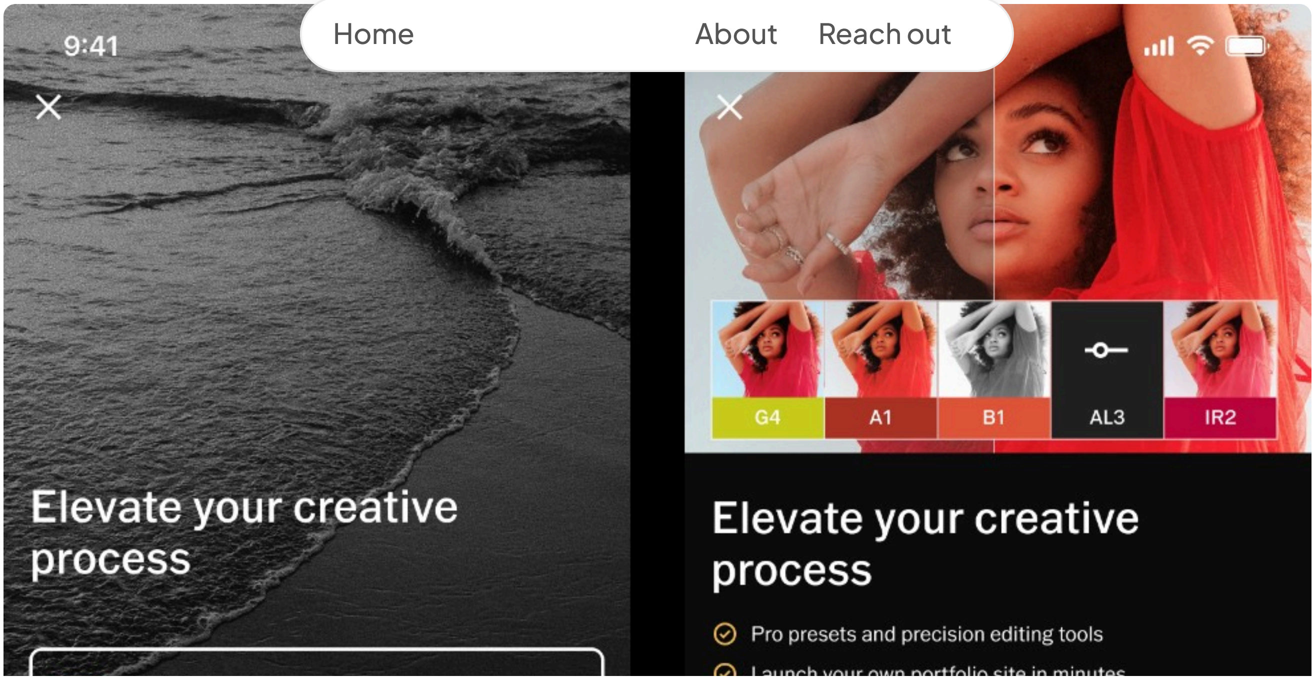
Animation

Cursor could not get the celebration animation right — hard-edged blobs instead of the soft mesh the design called for. Switched to Claude, which approached the SVG math differently and got there. The head of brand wanted to tweak parameters, so it shipped as an interactive playground with param

Same story with the Scout thinking indicator: six animation styles built as interactive prototypes. Both ship as live playgrounds, not hardcoded values.



Celebration animation: Cursor couldn't get the soft mesh right. Claude could. Shipped as a parametric playground so brand can adjust without a code change.



Paywall audit and variants: research and design in a single session.

Paywall and conversion design

I built a Cursor playground for designing VSCO paywalls: a live environment where I could iterate on layout, copy, and conversion patterns in real time against actual product context. Claude audited existing paywalls against conversion best practices, identified gaps, and generated variants directly in the playground.

Once the direction was right, the designs moved into Figma where Superwall could leverage them for implementation. Research, iteration, and handoff in a single workflow, without a specialist research pass or a separate design sprint.

Building team capability

One person moving fast is useful. A whole team moving fast changes what's possible. The risk with any new process is that it stays siloed — one person's skill, not the org's capability.

One designer on the team built and shipped Studio Pro largely in Cursor. AI fluency is now defined as a required competency at every IC level. The custom skills, always-on rules, template repo, and onboarding system that made this possible are documented separately.

I partnered with that designer directly before stepping back — their independent delivery was the proof of concept th

RELATED CASE STUDY

Operationalizing AI-Native Design →

The full operating model: rules, skills, handoff workflow, and how the team adopted it

The rest of the role

Design leadership involves a lot of work that doesn't show up in case studies: synthesizing long PRDs into decision-ready briefs, structuring hypotheses before committing to a direction, preparing research sessions, writing scope pushback, keeping engineering informed when the design system changes. These aren't glamorous. They're the operational surface area of the role.

Each of them has a repeatable workflow now. PRDs get summarized. Research sessions get prepped and debriefed. Design system changes travel to engineering with context instead of just a Figma update. The overhead of running the org doesn't disappear — it just stops requiring the same amount of manual effort each time.

I'm happy to go deeper on any of this. Reach out at sharonmillercreative@gmail.com.

RELATED

The org story only makes sense alongside the process. This is the process.

See the AI-native design process →

THE PRODUCT

The org story and the product story are different. This is the product.

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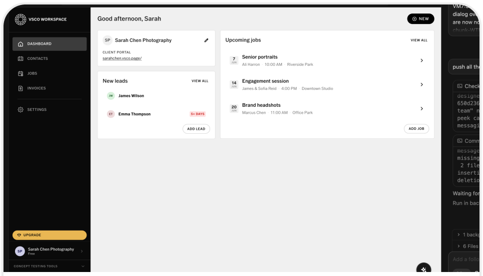
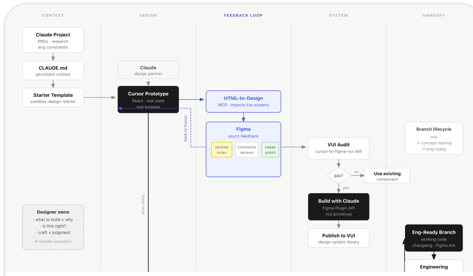


CASE STUDY

VSCO Workspace Simplified: AI-Native Design

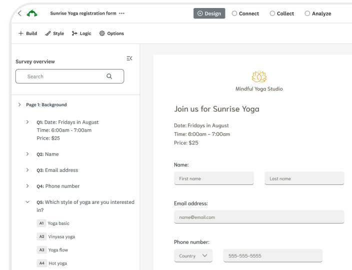
VSCO Workspace is live. A legacy...



CASE STUDY

Operationalizing AI-Native Design

Design stopped being a...



CASE STUDY

Survey Builder Transforma

SurveyMonkey's core autho

Let's connect

Open to head of design, director, and staff IC roles. Also consulting on AI-native design workflow and process.

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